Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 4.4 Guided Notes: Psychodynamic and Humanistic Theories of Personality

Unit 4: Social Psychology and Personality | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic4.4

Word Bank

Sublimation	*Conscious*	*Displacement*
Projection	*Psychodynamic Theory of Personality*	*Repression*
Reaction Formation	*Regression*	*Rationalization*
Personality	*Superego*	*Id*
Ego Defense Mechanisms	*Preconscious*	*Denial*
Unconscious	*Ego*	*Projective Tests*

1. The Psychodynamic Theory of Personality

Up until this point in the unit, we have focused on how external situations dictate human behavior. Now, we are pivoting to look inward. _____ is an individual's characteristic pattern of thinking, feeling, and acting. In this topic, we will explore two classic, opposing views: the Psychodynamic approach (focusing on hidden conflicts below the surface) and the Humanistic approach (focusing on growth, potential, and conscious choices).

Pioneered heavily by the work of Sigmund Freud, the _____ suggests that our personalities are driven largely by unconscious processes. According to this perspective, our minds are like icebergs—the massive, hidden part underwater contains unacknowledged desires, fears, and memories that heavily dictate our everyday thoughts and behaviors.

To understand how the hidden mind actually operates, Freud proposed that personality is made up of three competing structures. The _____ is the primitive part of personality that operates on the pleasure principle, seeking immediate gratification of basic drives and desires. The _____ represents our internalized moral compass, guiding behavior according to a sense of right and wrong. Caught in the middle is the _____, the rational part of personality that operates on the reality principle, balancing the demands of the other two structures and the constraints of the real world. This constant tug-of-war creates anxiety, which is exactly why the defense mechanisms below exist: to protect this mediator.

Freud also mapped these structures onto three levels of awareness. The _____ mind holds whatever thoughts, perceptions, and feelings you're actively aware of right now. The _____ holds information that isn't in your immediate awareness but can be easily retrieved when needed (like a phone number you haven't thought about in years). And the _____—the massive submerged part of the iceberg—contains the thoughts, memories, desires, and conflicts that remain hidden from awareness but still quietly influence behavior.

Apply It: Which Part of the Mind?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A toddler screams and grabs a candy bar off a store shelf the instant she sees it, demanding it right now.	
2	A man finds a wallet full of cash and feels intense guilt at the thought of keeping it, as an inner voice insists it is wrong.	
3	A hungry student badly wants to eat a lunch his friend left on a table, but he decides to wait and buy his own food after class.	
4	A student is actively thinking about the question in front of her on a test.	
5	Asked about it, a man easily recalls his childhood home address, even though he hasn't thought about it in years.	
6	A woman feels unexplained dread around dogs and has no awareness that a childhood scare is the cause.	

2. Ego Defense Mechanisms

Because the unconscious mind holds desires and memories that can cause intense anxiety, our mind employs _____. These mechanisms operate unconsciously and serve to protect the ego from psychological threats and anxiety. The AP exam specifically tests your ability to identify the following eight defense mechanisms:

- _____: Refusing to acknowledge a painful or threatening reality. (e.g., A partner refusing to believe their significant other is cheating despite clear evidence.)
- _____: Shifting unacceptable feelings or impulses from their original source to a safer, substitute target. (e.g., Yelling at your dog after having a bad day at work.)
- _____: Attributing one's own unacceptable thoughts or feelings onto someone else. (e.g., A liar assumes everyone else is constantly lying to them.)
- _____: Creating logical, socially acceptable explanations for behaviors that were actually driven by unconscious or less acceptable motives. (e.g., Claiming you didn't really want to go to the college that just rejected you anyway.)
- _____: Behaving in a way that is exactly the opposite of one's true (but unacceptable) feelings. (e.g., Being excessively friendly to a coworker you secretly despise.)
- _____: Retreating to an earlier, more infantile stage of development when faced with stress. (e.g., A teenager throwing a literal temper tantrum when their phone is taken away.)
- _____: Unconsciously blocking painful or unacceptable thoughts and memories from entering conscious awareness. This is considered the underlying basis of all other defense mechanisms.
- _____: Channeling unacceptable impulses into socially acceptable or even constructive activities. (e.g., Channeling deep-seated aggressive tendencies into a successful career as a professional boxer.)

Apply It: Which Defense Mechanism?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Despite repeated warnings from his accountant and several missed payrolls, a business owner insists his failing company is doing fine and refuses to look at the bills.	
2	A player furious at his coach for benching him goes home and angrily kicks his dresser.	
3	A man who secretly feels jealous of his friend's success insists that it is his friend who is jealous of him.	
4	A student who cheated on an exam tells himself that everyone cheats and the test was unfair anyway, so it wasn't really wrong.	
5	A man who is secretly attracted to a classmate he is embarrassed to like acts rude and hostile toward her at every chance.	
6	Stressed about moving to a new school, a ten-year-old starts sucking her thumb and demanding to be carried again.	
7	A woman who survived a frightening accident as a child has no memory of it at all, because her mind blocked it out without her knowing.	
8	A woman with intense, restless anger paints large, forceful canvases that win praise in galleries.	

3. Assessing the Unconscious

If the psychodynamic perspective relies on the unconscious mind, how do psychologists actually measure it? They use non-experimental methodologies known as _____. These tests present individuals with ambiguous stimuli and ask them to describe or tell a story about what they see. The theory is that people will "project" their preconscious and unconscious feelings, conflicts, and desires onto the ambiguous image. Famous examples include the Rorschach Inkblot Test and the Thematic Apperception Test (TAT).

Word Bank

Unconditional Positive Regard	*Ideal Self*	*Humanistic Theory of Personality*
Real Self	*Self-Actualizing Tendency*	*Self-Concept*

4. The Humanistic Theory of Personality

Emerging as a stark contrast to the dark, conflict-ridden psychodynamic perspective, the _____ focuses on the positive aspects of human nature. Psychologists in this camp emphasize that humans have free will and are fundamentally motivated to achieve their highest potential.

Central to this perspective is how we perceive our own identity. Carl Rogers proposed that our personality is heavily influenced by our _____—the organized set of beliefs and perceptions a person has about themselves, including their traits, abilities, and identity. Rogers broke this down into two distinct components:

- _____: A person's actual thoughts, feelings, behaviors, and characteristics as they currently exist.
- _____: The person one aspires to be—the image of oneself that reflects personal goals, values, and aspirations.

When these two are closely aligned, a person experiences congruence and a healthy personality. According to this theory, two primary motivating factors drive this personality development and growth:

- _____: An attitude of total acceptance toward another person. Carl Rogers believed that for a person to truly grow and bridge the gap between who they are and who they want to be, they must receive total love and acceptance from others, regardless of their flaws.
- _____: The innate drive within all humans to fulfill their potential, grow, and become the best version of themselves.

Apply It: Which Humanistic Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A man is asked to describe how he actually thinks, feels, and behaves day to day, not how he wishes he were.	
2	A teenager imagines the confident, generous, successful person she hopes to become one day.	
3	A father tells his daughter he loves her just as much whether she wins or loses the game, and no matter what mistakes she makes.	
4	Driven by an inner urge to grow and fulfill her potential, a retired accountant takes up painting and becomes a gifted artist.	
5	A boy's beliefs about himself, that he is smart, kind, and good at soccer, shape how he acts at school.	

📺 *Video Notes: "Measuring Personality" (Crash Course Psychology #22)*

This video covers more than today's topic. The sections on other approaches to personality (about 1:34 to 6:17, and 7:32 to 9:02) aren't part of Topic 4.4, and some of those ideas, like trait theory, come in Topic 4.5. The video also mentions Maslow's hierarchy of needs, which is not on the AP exam. Watch the video above, then answer the questions below on the parts that match today's material.

1. According to the video, what did Freud think our personalities depended on, and what methods did Freud and Jung use to get at the unconscious?

2. What does the video say about the Rorschach inkblot test and the Thematic Apperception Test (TAT), and what are projective tests meant to reveal?

3. What criticism did some psychologists have of the early psychoanalytic and humanistic theories, and what did it lead to?

4. How does the video say humanistic theorists tend to measure personality?

5. What are "possible selves," according to the video, and how do they motivate us?

5. Don't Trip Up! (AP Exam Exclusions)

⚠️ *Out of Scope – Psychosexual Stages: If you are taking an older practice test or using an outdated textbook, you might see questions about Freud's "stage theory of psychosexual development" (Oral, Anal, Phallic, Latency, Genital). Do not study this for the current AP Exam! The College Board has explicitly removed this stage theory from the scope of the test.*

⚠️ *Out of Scope – Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs: Similarly, while you must know the core concepts of humanism (unconditional positive regard and self-actualization), Maslow's hierarchy of needs is officially outside the scope of the AP Psychology Exam. Save your brain space for the required content!*

6. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. After having an incredibly stressful and demeaning day at work, a man comes home and unfairly yells at his innocent dog for barking, even though his real frustration has nothing to do with the dog at all. This defense mechanism, which shifts unacceptable feelings onto a safer target, is called:

- **A.** Reaction Formation
- **B.** Projection
- **C.** Displacement
- **D.** Sublimation

2. After being rejected from her top-choice dream college, a student immediately tells all her friends, "Honestly, I never really wanted to go there anyway, the campus was too small and the weather was terrible." This defense mechanism, which creates a logical excuse for an unacceptable disappointment, is called:

- **A.** Denial
- **B.** Reaction Formation
- **C.** Rationalization
- **D.** Sublimation

3. A woman who secretly and intensely despises one of her coworkers goes out of her way to act excessively warm, complimentary, and overly friendly toward that exact same coworker every single day at the office. This defense mechanism, which involves acting the complete opposite of one's true feelings, is called:

- **A.** Reaction Formation
- **B.** Displacement
- **C.** Regression
- **D.** Projection

4. A man who harbors deep-seated aggressive tendencies and violent impulses since childhood channels this energy into becoming an incredibly successful and disciplined professional boxer, using the sport as a constructive, socially acceptable outlet for his aggression. This defense mechanism is called:

- **A.** Rationalization
- **B.** Sublimation
- **C.** Regression
- **D.** Reaction Formation

5. A famous projective test, developed as an alternative to the classic inkblot test, presents individuals with ambiguous pictures of people in various scenes and asks them to construct a detailed story about what is happening, revealing unconscious themes through their narrative. This specific projective test is called the:

- **A.** Rorschach Inkblot Test
- **B.** Minnesota Multiphasic Personality Inventory
- **C.** Myers-Briggs Type Indicator
- **D.** Thematic Apperception Test (TAT)

6. According to Carl Rogers, the image of who a person truly aspires to become, reflecting their deepest personal goals, values, and life aspirations rather than their current reality, is called the:

- **A.** Real Self
- **B.** Superego
- **C.** Unconscious
- **D.** Ideal Self

7. A therapist practicing from a humanistic perspective makes a deliberate effort to fully accept and support her client without any judgment or conditions whatsoever, regardless of what mistakes or flaws the client reveals during their sessions together. This attitude of total, unconditional acceptance is called:

- **A.** Unconditional Positive Regard
- **B.** Self-Actualizing Tendency
- **C.** Reaction Formation
- **D.** Congruence

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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